irony of this story that the one who scared me witless to start with was the very same who brought me peace, purpose, I dare say even wholeness.

I had to tame him. It was at that moment that I realized this necessity. It was not a question of him or me, but of him and me. We were, literally and figuratively, in the same boat. We would live – or we would die – together. He might be killed in an accident, or he could die shortly of natural causes, but it would be foolish to count on such an eventuality. More likely the worst would happen: the simple passage of time, in which his animal toughness would easily outlast my human frailty. Only if I tamed him could I possibly trick him into dying first, if we had to come to that sorry business.

But there's more to it. I will come clean. I will tell you a secret: a part of me was glad about Richard Parker. A part of me did not want Richard Parker to die at all, because *if he died I would be left alone with despair*, a foe even more formidable than a tiger. If I still had the will to live, it was thanks to Richard Parker. He kept me from thinking too much about my family and my tragic circumstances. He pushed me to go on living. I hated him for it, yet at the same time I was grateful. I am grateful. It's the plain truth: without Richard Parker, I wouldn't be alive today to tell you my story.

I left Richard Parker in a jungle and waited for a ship. It pained me to see the animal without even turning his head to have a last glimpse. A ship did find me and I am now reunited with my family.

About The Author



Yann Martel was born in Spain to French Canadian parents. Martel's father worked as a diplomat and the family moved to Costa Rica, France, Mexico and Canada during Martel's childhood. He grew up speaking both French and English.

Martel studied philosophy at Trent University in Ontario, and later spent a year in India visiting religious sisters and zoos. His first three books received little critical or popular attention but with the publication of Life of Pi in 2001, Martel became internationally famous and he was awarded the Man Booker Prize in 2002.

Glossary

belch	-	expel air noisily
flotsam	-	debris floating in a river or sea
tarpaulin	-	a heavy waterproof sheet
incredible	-	unbelievable
conundrum	-	a riddle
asphyxiation	-	death due to lack of oxygen
putrid	-	rotting
guise	-	pretence
cauldron	-	a large bowl or pot
splinters	-	a long sharp fragment of material, often wood

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